

Greetings from 15 Feet High

Sometime in the last five years, I learned that my brother Colin has a somewhat abnormal perception of time. He never fails to underestimate how long it will take to do just about anything. Yesterday, he goaded me into hiking Manoa Falls.

“It only takes like thirty minutes, Sky. We’ll be back down here by two. Don’t be lazy.”

My disappointment after returning to the car a long two and a half hours later was my own fault, as I chose to believe him. We’ve been driving for about an hour now. Colin claimed our drive to North Shore Beach should take twenty minutes, so my real estimate sits at around an hour and a half. Not that I’m complaining. With the windows down and sunroof open, the island floods my senses: wind dancing freely through my hair, the mountain range overtaking my field of view, rays of sunlight warming my skin, a perfect collusion between laughter and music flowing from the speaker to my ears, and the salty air on my tongue. I tap my foot to the rhythm and take it all in with a smile.

“We’re here, Loser,” says my obviously loving brother. His words burst my bubble, and I returned to Earth with a simper. The drive distracted me from our purpose here on the North side of the island. *Why the heck did I agree to this?* My stomach twists at the thought of jumping off the iconic North Shore Diving Rock. I struggle to raise my hand in class and ride mid-sized roller coasters, both of which pale in comparison to falling from fifteen feet into the ocean.

My stomach feels like a bubbling witch’s cauldron as we unload the car and make our way to the blistering sand. I hop from one foot to the other before sprinting down to the ocean, hoping the water numbs the sand’s burning effects. We set up a base between a mother attempting to hide from the sun under her hat and lemon yellow jacket, a British family of four

who forgot to bring towels, and a small boy creating sandcastles bigger than him just to destroy them instantly.

I climb up sharp rocks glowing with a combination of reflective sunlight and forest green sludge. All eyes on the beach point to this rock and I'm sure they secretly rank the splashes as a jumper hits the water.

"When I fall and die, Colin, you're gonna have to explain that to Mom and Dad. And don't tell them I went out like this. Make it sound cool. Like a shark jumped up and got me," I bumbled.

"Look, Skylar," he started, "If you can jump, you can do anything. I'm telling you this is exactly what you need right now. Stop being a baby. Everyone does it. I have. All my friends have."

"All your friends are athletes. I forget how to swim sometimes. I resort to doggy paddling. We are not the same."

Stepping closer to the edge, the height from this peak to the water's surface seemed three times higher than it did from the sand. Blue waves crash into the shining black rock like bumper cars and bounce back into the ocean. From here, I can see miles away: the highway we drove on for an hour, cruise ships on the way to dock, beach-goers who resembled ants. I laugh deliriously and stare at Colin with a look that says, "You know this is not about to happen."

I can't muster up the courage to jump to my death, but he can muster up the audacity to push me to it, or at least attempt to.

"Colin, stop it! I'm so serious," I desperately shout as he approaches with a menacing smirk, but it is too late. Underestimating seems to be a family curse. I underestimate how far I am from the rock's edge, and backing away from my brother earns me a one-way ticket

downward. One second, I'm on top of the world, looking down on people and problems as if they're ants—the manageable Pharaoh ants, not those gargantuan carpenter pests. The next, I have sunk back under the surface of reality. Salt burns through my nose, my lungs flare like fire, my eyes sting like two bees have decided to take revenge on them, an intense ache surges from my side, and my head pounds.

I resurface and look around, not knowing where I am or what I'm doing. I hear the voices of strangers as they glance my way.

“Ooo, that looked like it hurt.”

“Dang! Did you see that?”

“She belly-flopped.”

“You seriously can't go down like that.”

I'm going to kill my brother. I'm going to make myself an only child. While I'm busy doggy paddling my way to land and simultaneously planning Colin's funeral, he gleefully leaps off the rock with an annoying smile that I'm going to slap off his face.

“Hahahaha! Skylar. It wasn't that bad. I swear,” he yells toward me.

I finally feel the ground under my feet and collapse to the floor. Pain still radiates throughout my whole body and my cheeks turn fire hydrant red at the thought of so many people seeing my uncoordinated flop. I half trudge and half crawl back to our base of towels and beach bags. My hair tangles and my blue eyeshadow dulls from their contact with the water.

“I'm telling Dad.”

“Skylar, no. He's going to lose his mind.”

“I think I have a concussion.”

“You don't.”

“My butt hurts.”

“You’ll be fine,” he laughs.

“I need water. I think I’m still drowning.”

“Here, you can have mine. And we can go to the shrimp truck you like on the way home.

Now don’t tell Dad.”

“I’ll think about it.”

“Mom’s asking for pictures. Smile.”

“Are you crazy? Look at me.”

“Just smile.” He clicks the picture and then deadpans at my exaggerated frown on the screen.

“I’m still sending it,” he continues with a brotherly chuckle.

“I’m never coming to visit you, again. I need my sofas and Netflix. What am I doing jumping off a rock?”

“Well, you didn’t jump. You fell. And now you can tell all your friends that you jumped off a cliff. How cool is that?”

We laugh it off under the shining sun, and any resentment I still hold dissipates as he takes me to my favorite shrimp truck like he promised. Maybe next time I visit, I can push him off our next hiking trail, but for now, I’m stuck with this dumb boy like I have been for eighteen years.

